

Getting an Edge in PD

This guide is about turning PD data into better draft decisions: baselines, tiering, scarcity, and defense-aware tie-breaks. The goal is simple: draft teams that score more runs and allow fewer runs, because that is what drives winning.

1) Define tiers, then draft by tiers

A **tier** is a **cluster** of similarly strong options separated by a **clear gap** from the next cluster. Tiers are the right abstraction for PD drafts because most picks are not “Player #17 vs #18” decisions—they’re “take a Tier 1 option now or risk falling into Tier 2 later.”

How to find tiers (practical):

- 1) Sort the pool by the metric you care about (e.g., SIERA for pitchers, wOBA for hitters).
- 2) Look for **gaps**—places where the numbers jump meaningfully and then stay in a new band.
- 3) Each band is a tier. The bigger the gap, the more actionable the tier break.

Example (pitching tier break): if the best block of pitchers is **3.3–3.5 SIERA** and the next major block is **4.2–4.5 SIERA**, that ~0.7–1.2 gap is a real tier break: it’s large enough that “above the line” is a different quality class than “below the line.”

How to interpret within a tier

Inside a tier, you treat players as “close enough” unless you have a strong reason not to. Here’s how to decide anyway: **Rank within a tier by fit, not by hairline stats:** if two hitters are both Tier 1 bats, a tiny wOBA difference is usually less important than defense and roster structure. **Use “position in the tier” language:** top-of-tier vs middle-of-tier vs bottom-of-tier. This keeps your decisions stable and prevents overfitting small differences. **Only treat micro gaps as real edges when the samples are massive** and the draft decision is otherwise identical.

2) Prioritize by scarcity: tier depth tells you what to draft first

A consistent PD edge is treating the draft like a market with supply and demand. The more Tier-1 options exist at a role/position, the less you need to spend an early pick there.

Heuristic: if the pitcher pool has *many* options in the highest tier and hitters have a sharper drop-off, draft bats first. You will likely see another Tier-1/Tier-2 pitcher later, but you might not see that bat again.

Draft room snapshot	What it implies	What to prioritize early
Many Tier-1 pitchers remain; bats have a steep drop-off	Pitching is abundant at the top; hitting scarcity is real	Draft best bats early; take arms later when value falls
Few Tier-1 pitchers remain; bats are deep	Ace scarcity; hitting can be replaced later	Secure a stabilizing arm, then shop bats by need
Both sides deep in top tiers	You can draft for structure/fit	Defense + positional scarcity as tie-breakers
Both sides shallow / messy	Variance-heavy room	Take the biggest tier-gap value; avoid micro edges

3) Use defense as a consistent tie-breaker inside tiers

Drafts frequently present “two good offensive players with marginal drift.” If they are in the same offensive tier, defense is a high-value tie-breaker: it turns close offensive choices into clearer run-differential choices (fewer extra bases, fewer extended innings, more converted outs).

Rule: when two bats are in the same offensive tier, take the better defender at a premium position. You’re converting a borderline offensive difference into run prevention that compounds across many games.

4) What to prioritize first across tournament settings (and why)

The “first priority” changes with format and environment because those change how run differential converts into wins: **Short formats are higher variance:** fewer games means more randomness; the better team’s edge has less time to show up. **Longer formats reward true edges:** over more games, run-production and run-prevention advantages have more chances to convert into wins. **Park/modifier settings change the run environment:** a pitcher-friendly setting makes each run more valuable; a hitter-friendly setting increases the cost of weak run prevention.

Why this is true (the run-differential link):

Baseball winning is tightly related to **runs scored** and **runs allowed** (a classic example is Pythagorean expectation / expected wins, which uses runs scored and allowed to estimate win percentage). In PD terms: drafting choices that increase expected runs for and decrease expected runs against will increase win probability over the tournament path.

Setting/format signal	What tends to matter more	Draft emphasis
Shorter formats / higher variance	Robustness + avoiding weak links	Stabilizing arm + premium defense; avoid fragile one-dimensional picks
Longer formats / more games	True edges compound	Lean into big tier gaps (wOBA/SIERA), then optimize defense/fit
Pitcher-friendly park/modifiers	Run creation is harder	Prioritize bats that stay above baseline; defense breaks ties
Hitter-friendly park/modifiers	Run prevention is harder	Prioritize arms that suppress damage; defense still breaks ties

Sources

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